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Author:
Frank Smith

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Fighting Stance

A Dramatic Monologue

Written by Frank Smith

SCENE I

Karate Dojo.

(Polished wood floors. Two walls full of mirrors. The third wall: a window looking onto a quad.)

ROWAN.

(ROWAN (22), perfect posture on the verge of seeming physically impossible, wears a karate gi, practicing the primary level Shotokan karate kata, Heian Shodan.)

ROWAN: *(Counting to ten in Japanese as he goes through his punches and kicks, nailing each.)* Ichi…ni…san…shi…go…roku…shichi…hachi…ku…juu. KI-YAH!!! *(Noticing the audience, he bows gracefully, before wiping sweat off his brow.)* 'Sup. I'm Rowan. SEMPAI Rowan. That sounded formal. It just means I've been doing karate longer than you all. But, umm…I'm sorry to say that you missed the training today. Better absent than late, I guess? Katrine Sensei does NOT like it when people are late. As in…she threatens them with bodily harm. *(Seeing the audience's worry.)* I'm kidding – she doesn't actually do that. Harm. She just threatens it. See, karate is all about self-defense. Not offense. Fighting is the absolute last resort. We're not about picking fights here. And Shotokan karate in particular has a bit of…reverence to it. Because you know the power you wield is dangerous. And that you only use it in very extreme circumstances.

(Rowan starts to pack up to leave…then smiles, looking at the audience.)

ROWAN: I feel bad that you came all this way, though. I could lead you through a training if you want. I'm not an instructor. But I am a purple belt! AKA an ADVANCED…intermediate student. So I could definitely show you a couple things. Would you like that? *(He drops his bag.)* Okay, great. Let's do it. How did you find out about the training, by the way? Did you see us at the activity fair? That's how I found out about karate last year. Before that, I used to do…well, nothing, quite honestly. I don't know, though. I think it was something about, knowing I was going to turn 21 later that year – and also starting drinking for the first time – that made my Mom say: Rowan. You live in New York City. It's dangerous out there. And you need to learn how to defend yourself. So, I figured: let's see what the college activities fair has on offer. And that's where I met the Shotokan karate club. More specifically: I met Tylan. I know…weird name, right? Sounds like Tylenol. His parents couldn't decide between Tyler and Dylan, so…they chose both! That was sort of his thing, getting the best of both worlds. He had red hair, but he also had blue eyes. I've always loved blue eyes, and he had these crystal blue ones that were just…piercing. Those, he got from his Dad. The red hair, he got from his Mom. It's not the most common look, red hair and blue eyes…but then again, Tylan isn't the most common person.

(Rowan starts stretching. He gestures for the audience to do the same.)

ROWAN: You want to get nice and limber before we get into any real training. Trust me, you will be in pain tomorrow…but it's a proud pain. That's sort of what being friends with Tylan was like. Proud pain. I'm talking a lot about him, huh? Sorry! I'm a sharer. I first noticed Tylan from afar – those eyes, that hair. I walked right up to him at the activities fair. I asked him point-blank: are those contacts you're wearing? They were that blue! They didn't even look real. He says yes, calls me an idiot – which I find funny, for some reason – then asks me what I know about karate.

I say not much, other than what I've seen on Power Rangers. And he says, well then, I have a lot to teach you, kohai. That means younger student. Which is what you all are to me.

(Rowan stops stretching.)

ROWAN: Okay, nice and stretched out? Good. First thing I'll teach is how we move in karate. Crescent stepping. It's like this. *(He demonstrates, squatting down and arcing his feet out as he moves.)* I know it seems awkward, but you get used to it after a while. Just…practice, okay? *(He observes the audience moving.)* Yeah, it's a start. When I first did it, I looked ridiculous. But Tylan helped out a lot. He'd stand next to me at every training, saying I was his personal kohai. He'd watch, whisper suggestions – which sometimes made Katrine Sensei mad – but it helped me get better faster than all the other students. Tylan was a green belt, which is a degree below what I am now. But from how confident he was, you would've sworn he was a 1st degree Black Belt. He was only a year older than me…but he seemed like he knew so much more. I actually turned 21 on a day where we had a karate training. And when it's your Birthday in the club, you get to spar against all the other members. Everybody has one shot, so it's up to you to defend yourself. Obviously, I was newer, and most people got in a good punch or kick. Tylan took it easy on me: he went for the face. But the face block – one of the first things I'll show you all –

(Rowan demonstrates, arcing his arm up from below his waist to over his head. He gestures for someone in the audience to punch, before blocking it flawlessly.)

ROWAN: It's a pretty effective block. So, since I have a September Birthday, I'm pretty much the only one of my friends who had turned 21 already. Except Tylan, who was a year older than me. And he said, "Come on, Kohai, I'm getting you drunk." And what could I say? He was my sempai, my older student. Saying no to getting wasted with him would have been…highly disrespectful! Besides, my Mom had always taught me to be gracious to people who show you kindness. And he was definitely showing it to me. With beer, with a chicken salad, with another beer, with a shot, with another shot. And since I had literally never had a drop of alcohol before in my life, that was enough to get me pretty litty. Now, as some of you may have guessed from the way I talk about Tylan – I had a crush on him. I had no idea if he could tell or not. But see, I wasn't exactly out to anyone yet. Not because I felt like they'd be MEAN to me…but I worried they wouldn't be NICE. And that was enough to keep me closeted. As it is with a lot of young queer people. But Tylan, who treated me like a king? Wow. That was more than I ever could have hoped for. It felt like being kissed a thousand times, all over. And that is when he brought up kissing. He said that a 21st Birthday was a lot like New Year's. And that I deserved to get a kiss. We walked around, talking to girls. No one seemed interested. Neither was I. Just when I was ready to give up, he asked me: have you ever been kissed by a guy before? I said no. He stared at me. For a long time. It was awkward. And…attractive. I asked: have YOU ever been kissed by a guy before? He said yes. Who was it, I asked? A friend, he answered. And…what was it like, I questioned, my heart beating into my throat at this point. He said pretty nice. I smiled, a really dopey, still pretty drunk smile, and said: I'll have to take your word for it. And he said: you don't have to take my word for it. He walked right up to me. Looked me straight in the eye. Moved his face toward mine. Hand on my cheek. A few fingers on my neck. And…that was my first gay kiss. But, you know when you're gay, like I am: it was just…my first kiss. And it was a pretty great one. I think. Like I said, I was DRUNK, so…I'll have to take my word for it.

(Rowan demonstrates a stomach block by holding up his wrist, then thrusting it down.)

ROWAN: And that's how you defend a strike against your stomach. Don't worry, we'll move on to actual attacks soon. Like I said: defense is the priority. Perceiving the threat. Reacting only when you must. Speaking of reactions: I was a little surprised when all we did after the kiss was…walk home. Though I did get a sweet check-in text from Tylan of, "Tonight was so much fun. More soon, please. Of all of it." I woke up the next morning, the most excited for karate training. I showed up a few minutes early, looked around…no Tylan. It's now only a minute before we start – no Tylan. He showed up JUST before Katrine Sensei started us off. Good for him, because she would have threatened to kick his ass so hard. Then, you know, not actually done it. But that day, he wouldn't stand next to me. He stood as far away as he could. And it was quite honestly one of my worst trainings ever. I kept wondering what I did, what I said, if I was just a drunk, gay mess, and I did something awful to him. After practice, he FLED. That night, I heard a knock at my door: it was Tylan. My roommates kind of gave me eyes, like, he doesn't SEEM like he's here to study. And Tylan noticed, so quickly ushered me into my room. Without my even having to ask, he said he was sorry for how he avoided me at karate training. He ran a hand through his perfect red hair. Blinked at me with those beautiful blue eyes. But…he wasn't out yet. Neither am I, I said. Yeah, he said, but with you, people, like…they know. They don't with me. Ouch, I said. Not that it should have been an ouch. But coming from him, it felt like it. He said he was glad he could tell right away with me…it's how he knew it'd be okay to kiss me. I smiled. 'Cause he was right. So, we kissed again. He said, "Just think of us like agents: secret, sexy agents." I REALLY liked the sound of that. So, we kissed again. And again. And…

(Rowan raises his arm, and swings it around in front of his face.)

ROWAN: So this is a mid-range block. Can be used for the face, or the stomach, depending on – you know, where you block. Tylan and I, we went on with this "sexy, secret agents" game for about a month. I come to think of him as my boyfriend – though he wouldn't call ME that – but his kisses…were perfect. I loved running my hand through his hair. Smelling him, especially after training. I was smitten. And sometimes at training, he'd say he had to use the bathroom – at the same time that I had to use the bathroom – and on our way back to training, we'd kiss out in the hallway. But as soon as someone would show up, we'd stop, and act like we never even saw each other. It didn't totally bother me. It didn't feel like what I'd want to do forever. But what we had was nice, I thought. I didn't perceive the threat. One training, we snuck off for a bathroom trip, followed by a hallway kiss. I really did have to pee that time. Only, when we started to kiss…Katrine Sensei was there. She'd gotten suspicious of how we always ran off at the same time. Worried we were doing something we shouldn't. I guess she was right. I tried to cover, saying I know what it looks like, but we were just hugging. Katrine Sensei could see exactly what was happening. She said it's no big deal, whether it was hugging, or…she didn't care. No one did. I'm so relieved, I just burst out: yeah, who cares if you've kissed a guy before, right? Katrine Sensei laughed. I had NEVER seen her laugh. Tylan scowled. I had NEVER seen him scowl. He said HE'D never kissed a guy. He turned on me and said: have YOU? Because if you have. It's gross. I didn't even know what to say to that. I just felt…well, gross. Thank God for Katrine Sensei, telling us both to get back inside, and take separate bathroom breaks from now on. Because if she hadn't prevented us from talking further…I might have broken up with him right then and there. Of course, I didn't, because why would I learn my lesson that early, right?

(Rowan checks in with the audience. Seeing they're ready, he nods, and throws his first punch – it's swift and powerful.)

ROWAN: And when it comes to attacking – we're finally there, yay! – you're not here to do some martial arts movie style beatdown. It's about being swift, and deadly. One strong punch to the face or gut – your opponent is incapacitated, and you can escape. Escaping isn't always that easy, though. I was absolutely furious with Tylan after how he acted in front of Katrine Sensei. I think I stomped all the way back to my dorm. In fact, I know I did, because a few random girls pointed it out to me. Giggling…but also asking me if I was okay. And I thought: why are these random strangers able to show me kindness? But my boyfriend, who won't even call me that, can't? I raced into my room. None of my roommates were home, fortunately, which was good. I couldn't face them. I was way too embarrassed. Embarrassed I let myself be treated like that, embarrassed at how much they knew – or didn't know. Heard a knock at the door. I didn't answer. Phone buzzed. I didn't answer. Phone rang. For five minutes straight. Finally, I answered the door, and it was…Katrine Sensei. This would be like if you were Catholic, and God stopped by your room, when you were expecting…well, your boyfriend. She said it's none of her business, what's going on between Tylan and me, but that she hoped, sincerely hoped, that I was getting out of it just as much as I was putting in. I thanked her, closed the door, and just… broke down sobbing. I wasn't getting enough out of it. I knew I wasn't. I knew that all along.

(Rowan focuses in before performing a powerful kick. He laughs, watching the audience try.)

ROWAN: The power is really supposed to come from your legs. Not your back. That's the whole point of doing the crescent stepping. To teach you how to stay grounded. Draw your power from the Earth. From within. To support your back and spine. We all need a little help with our back-bones. So it was time for another training. Tylan once again waited until the very last minute to show. I walked over to him. In no uncertain terms, I laid out how wrong it was for him to act like I was a stranger. He said "You knew what we were: secret, sexy agents." Nothing more, nothing less. As far as the world was concerned, he was straight. And both he and I needed to keep up that appearance. I looked him in the eye and said: either you're straight, or I'm your boyfriend. You don't get the best of both worlds. I started to walk away. He grabbed me by the arm. Hard. Don't walk away from me, he said. Don't you ever walk from me. I'm frozen. Stuck in the whirlpool of those beautiful blue eyes. That tousled, fiery red hair. Katrine Sensei had to walk up and physically pull us apart. Time to train, she said. Tylan went to the opposite end of the lineup. I walked up and stood right next to him. But said nothing. Yet. And wouldn't you know it? That day just happened to be Tylan's Birthday. Meaning we all got to take a shot at him. I was kind of reluctant. But Katrine Sensei said Tylan and I deserved the exact same treatment. *(Rowan acts out all the following movements.)* I rushed up to him. He had trained me well – I landed a hit. So did he. It was harder than it needed to be. I went for a kick. I missed on purpose, but he still blocked me pretty aggressively, almost throwing me down to the floor. Then, he went to punch me square in the face. And…I blocked it perfectly. He went for it again. I blocked every single time. I perceived the threat. Shocked, spitting mad, Tylan got in my face, and whispered: "How dare you do this to me. Your Sempai. Your…boyfriend." I stepped away and said, loud enough for the whole room to hear: "You are nothing to me." Katrine Sensei was ready to break things up, but she didn't have to. Tylan stormed off, face dripping from sweat, or tears, or both – he never came back to train. Ended as a green belt, which I have now surpassed.

(Rowan performs the remainder of the first kata, Heian Shodan, that the audience's arrival interrupted at the start.)

ROWAN: One last thing we have to talk about when it comes to Shotokan karate: kimei. It means spirit. It's what separates a good day of training from a great day. If you've watched Power Rangers, like me, and remember all the AY-YAH! and KI-YAH! the Rangers would yell: that's kimei. Spirit. The feeling that no matter what, you'll be able to perceive a threat, and defend yourself accordingly. With the power from your own body, as well as that of your friends and allies. Which we now are, my kohai. Come on, give me a good yell. I'll teach you Heian Shodan, the kata I just completed. But the thing that's more important than any individual move is kimei. Do you have it? Can you show me some? *(Off the audience's response.)* Then say it with me. Throw out a punch, a kick, or any kind of block, and kimei it up, kohai. One-two-three: KI-YAH!

THE END.